WHERE FRIENDSHIPS BEGIN

Start with the dinner table that rescued Mehra's weekend. The concept of dinner with strangers is not a novelty. The social collective Thrifty X runs 'Dine-in with Strangers' at restaurants in Gurugram, Delhi, Kolkata, Bhubaneswar and Thiruvananthapuram; seats are capped at 8–12 to keep tables intimate—and routinely sell out. In September, their listings showed Gurugram dinners and city hops—events in cities across India at the same time—alongside formats like 'Game Nights with Strangers'. Rent-a-friend is now a reality too. Apps like DosthAdda, FRND and PalMatch—as well as Facebook and Telegram communities—list profiles of people who rent out their time for a fee starting at Rs 50 an hour. One can scroll through bios, apply filters for age, language or interests, and book someone. These companions are meant to be strictly non-romantic and governed by clear rules: no intrusive personal questions and no private locations. A companion arrives at the agreed venue and spends the booked duration.

On Sunday mornings, Bengaluru's Cubbon Park is dotted with silent reading circles. Cubbon Reads, which began in 2023, grew into a weekly gathering: at its peak, over 500 readers gathered under Tree No. 3256. The template travelled briskly to over 60 offshoots, from Bessy Reads on Chennai's beachfront to Juhu and Bandra Reads in Mumbai. It is simple: read together, then talk—about books or nothing in particular. It is how Pranav Sinha, 23, an advertising intern, found his first friend circle in Mumbai: a lent pen, a shared snack and, by the third Sunday, a plan with pals.

City Girls Who Walk Delhi began in March 2023 with seven women. Since then, the community says it has walked with over 4,000 across Sunder Nursery, Lodhi Garden, Purana Qila and Amrit Udyan. Weekend routes, posted on Instagram, draw 90–100 walkers—ensuring safety in numbers. Neha Kapoor, 23, an architecture student, arrived for an internship. "I just had to show up in comfy shoes," she says. "By the end, I had a brunch invite and a buddy."

Prefer improv to ambling? In Delhi, Kaivalya Plays runs open jams where first-timers play and perform—storytelling, stand-up comedy, theatre, music—alongside regulars. Warm-ups reduce self-consciousness and the post-jam chai often leads to deeper bonds. In the board-game scene, newcomers learn Catan or Ticket to Ride in community meets in Mumbai's Andheri and Bandra; in Bengaluru, cafés seat solos with groups at open tables.



"THERE'S A DESPERATE NEED FOR CONNECTION THAT LIKES AND FILTERS CAN'T MEET. YOUNG PEOPLE ARE CREATING INTENTIONAL OFFLINE SPACES BECAUSE PRESENCE ITSELF IS REASSURANCE"

DR UPASANA CHADDHA
Delhi-based psychologist

If wielding a pencil is one's forte, there are sketch-crawls organised by Bengaluru-based Penciljam that fills lawns and boulevards. Throughout August, over 100 sketchers gathered under trees at the National Gallery of Modern Art. Tara Iyer, 26, a sustainability consultant, stumbled into a session after a tough week. "Someone passed me a kneaded eraser like a secret handshake. I drew leaves badly for two hours and got invited back."

Some formats cut out the performance bit. In the Human Library—a concept where a reader 'borrows' a person for 15 minutes and listens to her life experiences—you enter as strangers, leave as acquaintances, sometimes as allies. Blindfolded Conversations, rotated by Thrifty X through Delhi and Bengaluru and by Justbaat across India, go further: People talk with eyes covered, so looks and labels don't get in the way and talk moves to the honest bits. The set-up lowers social anxiety, helping strangers build judgement-free rapport.

Cycling groups have their days too. In Kochi, the women-led Freedom Night Ride has become a city ritual, drawing enthusiasts from late-teens to people in their 60s, who roll through the old city's lanes.

And because this is India, even the fake wedding—a ticketed, tongue-in-cheek *shaadi* where nobody marries—has arrived. You dress up, there is a *baraat* and cake, and the aim is to dance and befriend. It is all delightfully absurd but, like in real weddings, you meet people you will recognise next time.

BELONGING IS KEY

Why do these formats work? Low-stakes curation helps—a facilitator at dinner, or a host who seats a shy newcomer beside a steady one. Shared environs and tasks lead to bonding—pedalling the same night route, reading under the same tree. Inclusivity is built in too: women-only walks, 'come-as-you-are' art meets. As Dr Parikh puts it, "Belonging isn't a grand gesture. It's the small, repeated invitation: see you next week."

Affordability helps too. Many formats are free (walking clubs, sketch crawls) or low-ticket (Rs 300–Rs 1,200 for board-game nights and open improv). On a weekend, a quick scroll reveals open mics for people to perform, mystery walks and sell-out suppers. The appeal? You show up, the structure does the heavy lifting, you leave with friends.

In a world saturated by screens, Gen Zers have embraced offline friendships to anchor identity, soothe anxiety and build family outside bloodlines. Make eye contact. Share a bench. Split a sandwich. It is striking how quickly conversation becomes connection when a city gives you a place to sit and express yourself. ■